

“let’s have a big party,” or “you can’t take it with you.” What Mr. Leffert wanted to hear instead was whether I’d prepared for reasonable long-term growth, stability, security, the mortgage payments, the children’s college education, and whether I was properly annuitized, and so forth.

To explain how I might better clarify my objectives, Mr. Leffert turned to his blackboard and gave a 15-minute lecture, complete with diagrams he drew with the felt-tip pen. It had to do with putting a coordinating umbrella over the chaos of my life, which he’d divided into asset management, tax planning, estate planning, insurance planning, and retirement planning. As he talked about the retirement planning, he drew a little happy face of a grandpa with a beard.

Between you and me, I was thinking about my actual household of bounced checks, forgotten payments, untold dollars in unpaid parking tickets, the silly monthly budgets that we’d tried and then abandoned, the thousands of dollars of incidental expenses, and wondered what possible relation it all had to the pie graph that Mr. Leffert had so carefully devised. I blurted out that I had no life insurance. This was as much a shock to Mr. Leffert as if I’d admitted to wearing my wife’s brassiere. I told him I didn’t know our annual income, since with me being a free-lance writer and my wife a real estate agent, income is always unpredictable. Finally I confessed that my life had nothing to do with the “totally integrated whole” that he had created with his felt-tip.

He sat down, leaned over, and in a fatherly tone advised me not to worry, that all people in need of financial planning believe their situation to be hopeless. He said he suspected that however sloppy my family finances, I was a redeemable case. He handed me a brochure published by his company, opened it to an inside page, and showed me the part that said: “Very few people whom we have met have this vital total and continuing perspective on their financial life.”

Mr. Leffert soon got to the hard part. Before we could even think about a plan, there would have to be a “basic data gathering of from two to twenty hours,” during which his staff would pore over my family’s grocery bills, receipts, and so forth and “take a picture.” After that the data gatherers would come back to the